Who Is Arguing for Education?

Serbia's students won an election, France's and Italy's are fighting their budgets, and the numbers behind all three

Independent research project, October 2026

Eight Python models built on official data from Eurostat, the IMF, the OECD and Serbia's electoral commission.

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Introduction

On Sunday 25 October 2026 a list of university students won a general election in Serbia. With 96.9% of polling stations counted, the Student List had 52.64% of the vote and the list led by Aleksandar Vučić, who has run the country in one office or another since 2012, had 39.22% [SD1]. Vučić conceded on election night and said his own sample count gave the students between 135 and 140 seats and his party about 105 [EN1]. It started with a concrete canopy that fell on people waiting at the railway station in Novi Sad on 1 November 2024 and killed 16 of them [AJ1].

At the same time two much richer countries next door have their own students on the street. In France it began in a lycée in Créteil in September, spread to more than a thousand schools and, on 17 October, merged with the cost of living marches into a crowd the Interior Ministry put at 550,000 [WIKI1, AJ2]. In Italy students marched in dozens of cities on 16 October against the state of their schools, the cost of studying and a new decree on foreign pupils, under the banner of a "No Meloni Day" [IP1].

The question that started this report is a simple one. If France has HEC and Italy has Bocconi, and both countries are full of clever people, why is the average so low, and who is actually arguing for education? Looking at the photos from the marches, it is tempting to conclude that it is mostly immigrants. I think that is the wrong reading of the photos and I will show why with numbers rather than opinions. But the question underneath it is a good one, and the answer is different in each of the three countries.

The report has three parts. The first is Serbia, what the students won and what they were up against. The second is the education gap, which turns out to be an Italian problem much more than a French one. The third is who is on the street and why, including the immigration question. As in my earlier reports, everything rests on my own Python models, eight this time, built on official data from Eurostat, the IMF, the OECD and Serbia's Republic Electoral Commission.

Key terms

Tertiary attainment is the share of people, usually aged 25 to 34, who hold a degree of any kind. Eurostat counts two year vocational degrees, bachelor's, master's and doctorates (ISCED levels 5 to 8). The EU has set a target of 45% by 2030.

Short cycle tertiary means two year vocational degrees after school, such as the French BTS. They count as degrees in the attainment figures.

PISA is the OECD's test of 15 year olds in maths, reading and science, run every three years. The latest published round is 2022.

NEET means young people not in employment, education or training.

Lycée is a French upper secondary school for pupils aged about 15 to 18.

RIK is Serbia's Republic Electoral Commission, which publishes the official count.

D'Hondt is the formula Serbia uses to turn votes into seats. It slightly favours the largest lists.

Chapter 1 Serbia, the students who won

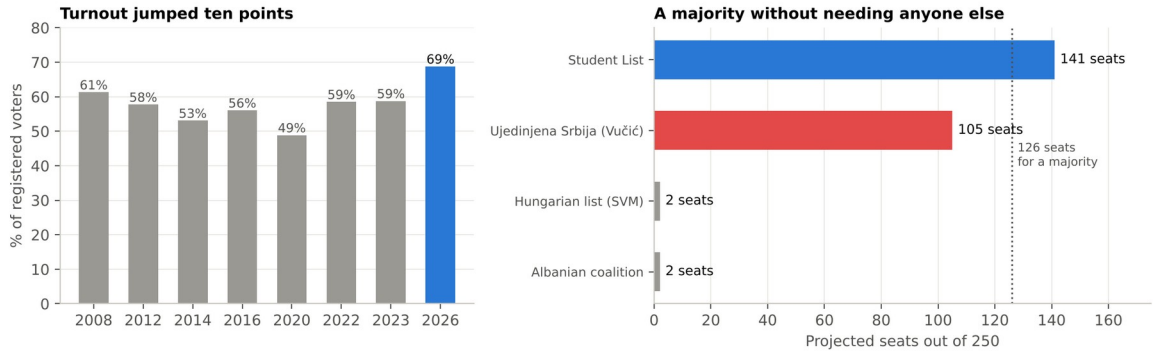
From a canopy to a majority

The Novi Sad station had just been renovated when its concrete canopy fell, and for many Serbians the deaths became a symbol of what they saw as a state where contracts mattered more than safety and nobody was ever held responsible [AJ1]. University students blockaded their faculties and began marching. The peak came in Belgrade on 15 March 2025, when the Archive of Public Gatherings, an independent group that counts crowds, put the protest at between 275,000 and 325,000 people and the police said 107,000 [BETA1]. Under that pressure Vučić, who was president, resigned in September 2026 and called early elections, running at the head of his party's list [AJ1, EN1]. The students formed their own list, led in the campaign by Ilija Srdanović, a professor of medicine in Novi Sad, and promised to tackle corruption, take party politics out of institutions and restore citizens' rights [AJ1, N1].

How big the win was

Figure 1 puts the result in context (Model 01). Turnout at the counted stations was 68.8%, ten points higher than at the last election in December 2023 and higher than at any parliamentary vote since at least 2008 [SD1, WIKI2]. Al Jazeera reports it as the highest in more than 30 years [AJ1]. The registered diaspora vote more than doubled to over 100,000 people [EWB2]. Vučić's list fell by almost nine points compared with 2023 and finished 572,605 votes behind the students [SD1, POL1].

Figure 1: Serbia's students won outright on the highest turnout in decades



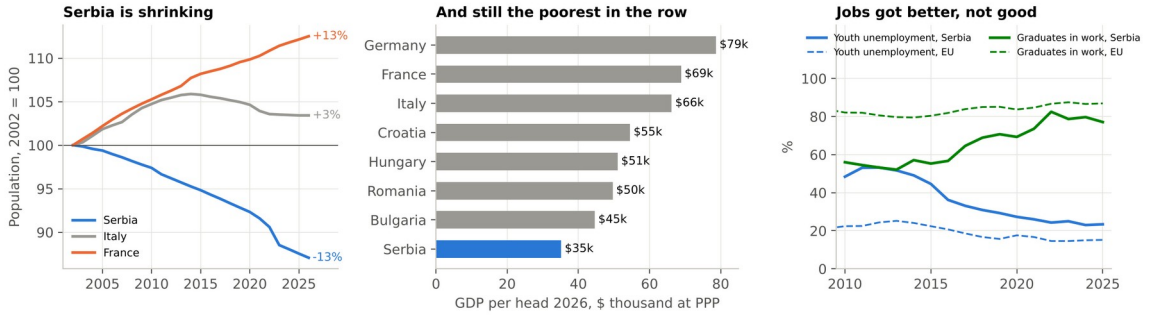
Source: author's model 01 (D'Hondt with the 3% threshold and the 35% minority bonus); RIK preliminary count at 96.9% of stations via sd.rs (26 Oct 2026); Wikipedia.

To turn the votes into seats I rebuilt the Serbian system in Python. All 250 seats come from one national list by the D'Hondt formula, lists need 3% of the vote, and lists of national minorities are exempt from that threshold and have their votes counted at 135% since a reform in 2020 [WIKI2, EWB1]. Only two ordinary lists clear 3%. On the RIK count my model gives the Student List 141 seats, Vučić's list 105, and two seats each to the Hungarian and Albanian minority lists. That is 15 seats more than the 126 needed for a majority, so the students can govern alone. Smaller minority lists below 0.5% could still take a seat or two in the final count, but nothing plausible gets the students under 126.

What they were up against

The odd thing about Serbia is that by the usual economic measures Vučić did quite well. Unemployment fell from about 26% to 8 or 9%, GDP nearly tripled in euros and foreign investment rose from about €800 million a year to a record €5.2 billion in 2024 [AJ1]. Figure 2 shows why that was not enough (Model 02).

Figure 2: Vučić delivered growth, but the young kept leaving



Source: author's model 02; Eurostat demo_gind, une_rt_a, edat_lfse_24; IMF World Economic Outlook (Oct 2026) via OpenBB.

Serbia had 7.50 million people in 2002 and has 6.53 million now, a fall of 13% at the same time as Italy grew by 3% and France by 13% [DATA1]. Part of the sharp drop in 2022 is a census correction rather than people leaving in one year, but the direction over two decades is clear. A country with hardly any immigration only shrinks like that through low birth rates and young people moving abroad. Youth unemployment has fallen from 53% in 2012 to 23%, which is real progress, but it is still well above the EU's 15%, and only 77% of recent graduates are in work against 87% in the EU [DATA1].

Income is the other half. At purchasing power parity the IMF puts Serbia's GDP per head at about $35,000 in 2026, the lowest of the eight countries in the chart and roughly half of Italy's [DATA2]. On the IMF's own forecasts Serbia grows faster than Croatia, but at those rates it would still take about 20 years to catch it up. If you are 22, have a degree, and can earn double in Vienna or Munich, the maths is simple. The students were not asking for more growth. They were asking for a state that does not drive their friends abroad.

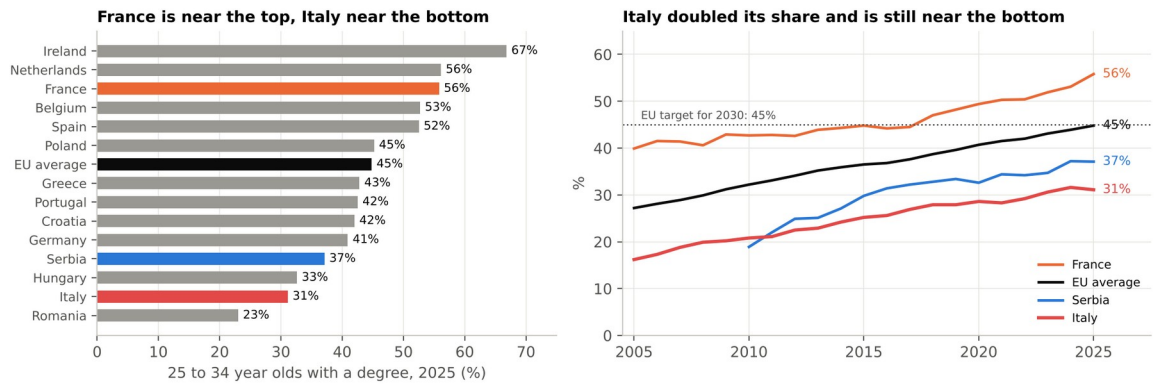
> **Question** **Does this mean Serbia will now join the EU and use the euro?**
>
> **Answer** Not soon. Serbia has been an EU candidate since March 2012 and has been negotiating since January 2014, yet by November 2025 only 2 of its 34 negotiating chapters had been provisionally closed [WIKI5]. It uses the dinar. A government that is serious about the rule of law will make the talks easier, but accession takes years and the euro only comes after membership and two more years of tests. The bigger change is at home. The new majority has to deliver on Novi Sad, on the courts and on the media, with a parliament where its opponents still hold about 105 seats.

Chapter 2 Is the average really low?

France is not the problem

This is where I have to push back on the starting point. Figure 3 shows the share of 25 to 34 year olds with a degree in 2025 (Model 03). France is at 55.8%, eleven points above the EU average of 44.8% and ahead of Germany, Spain and Belgium [DATA1]. France does not have a low average. Italy does. At 31.1% it is second from the bottom among the countries I looked at, ahead only of Romania and behind Serbia at 37.1%.

Figure 3: The 'low average' is an Italian problem, not a French one



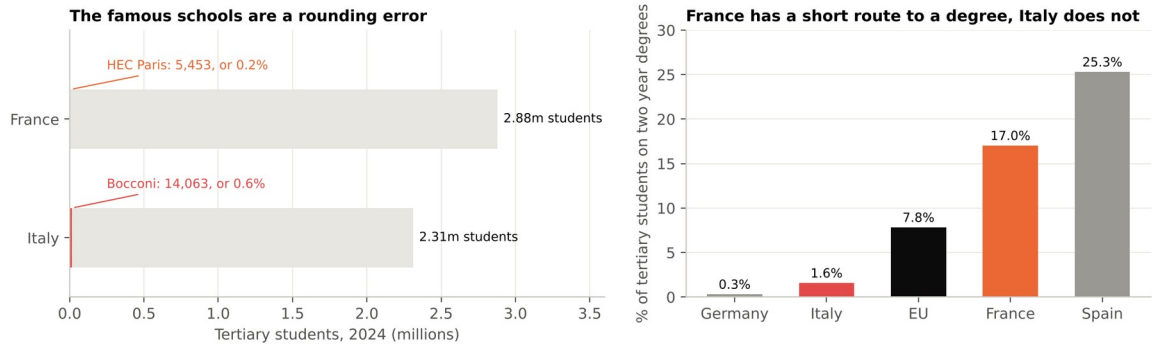
Source: author's model 03; Eurostat edat_lfse_03 (tertiary attainment, ISCED 5 to 8, age 25 to 34).

Italy has improved a lot. In 2005 only 16.2% of young Italians had a degree, so the share has almost doubled. But it has gained about 0.6 points a year over the last decade while the EU has gained 0.8, so the gap is getting wider, not narrower. At its own pace Italy would need around 24 years to reach the 45% that the EU wants every country to reach by 2030.

Why Bocconi does not move the average

Bocconi and HEC are excellent schools, and that is exactly why they are small. Figure 4 puts them next to the whole system (Model 04). Bocconi has 14,063 students, which is 0.6% of the 2.31 million people in Italian higher education [BOC1, DATA1]. HEC Paris lists 5,453 postgraduate students, 0.2% of France's 2.88 million, and charges more than €70,000 for its flagship master's programme [WIKI3]. A country's average is made by its mass universities and by how many people go to university at all, not by its famous names. Asking why Bocconi does not lift the Italian average is a bit like asking why Ferrari does not lift the average Italian car.

Figure 4: Averages are made by mass systems, not by elite schools



Source: author's model 04; Eurostat educ_uoe_enrt01 (2024); Università Bocconi (2025 to 2026); Wikipedia (HEC Paris).

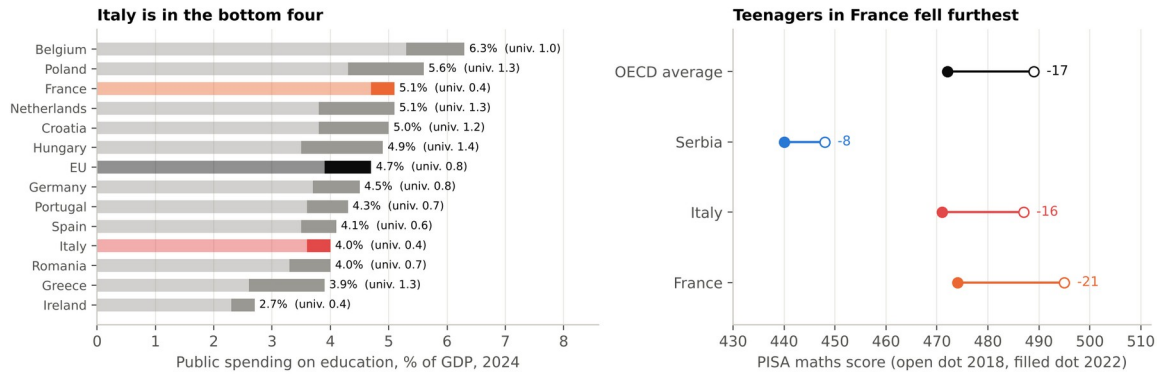
The right side of Figure 4 shows a structural reason for the gap that rarely makes the news. In France 17% of students are on two year vocational degrees, the BTS and similar diplomas, and in Spain it is 25%. In Italy it is 1.6% [DATA1]. These short degrees count towards the attainment figure, so France and Spain have a quick route to the 45% target that Italy has barely built. As a rough upper bound, if Italy had a two year sector as large as France's relative to its other degrees, its 31.1% would be closer to 37% (Model 04). Germany is the exception that proves the point, because it trains the same kind of people through apprenticeships, which do not count as degrees at all. Something else is changing in Italy too,

because enrolment at private institutions more than doubled from 257,000 in 2018 to 542,000 in 2024 [DATA1].

Money in, results out

Figure 5 shows the money (Model 05). Italy's government spent 4.0% of GDP on education in 2024 against 4.7% for the EU and 5.1% for France, and only 0.4% of GDP on universities, half the EU's 0.8% [DATA1]. Of the 13 EU countries I looked at only Ireland, whose GDP is inflated by multinational accounting, and Greece spent less in total, with Romania level. France's university line is also 0.4%, but France books part of its higher education spending under other headings such as research, so that number understates it.

Figure 5: Italy underfunds universities and France's schools are slipping



Source: author's model 05; Eurostat gov_10a_exp (COFOG 09 and 09.4); OECD PISA 2018 and 2022.

The French problem shows up earlier, in school. Between 2018 and 2022 French 15 year olds lost 21 points in PISA maths, falling from 495 to 474, slightly more than the OECD average fall of 17 [WIKI4]. Italy lost 16 points to 471, and Serbia 8 points to 440. Covid hit everyone, so the falls are not all policy, but in France they land on top of exactly the complaints the lycée students are making, which are missing teachers, overcrowded classes, crumbling buildings and timetables that leave them exhausted [WIKI1]. The "good minds" part of the question also needs a correction. Italian and French teenagers score almost exactly at the OECD average. They are neither better nor worse than their peers in other rich countries, which is a long way from the image their best universities give.

Question **So is French education actually fine?**

Answer Its universities produce a lot of graduates, so on the headline number France is doing well. Its schools are a different story. The PISA fall, the teacher shortages and the €54 billion of savings and tax rises in the 2027 budget, with a fourth year of frozen civil service pay scales, are what the French students are protesting about [AJ2, WIKI1]. The French fight is about the quality of schooling for teenagers, not about how many people get degrees.

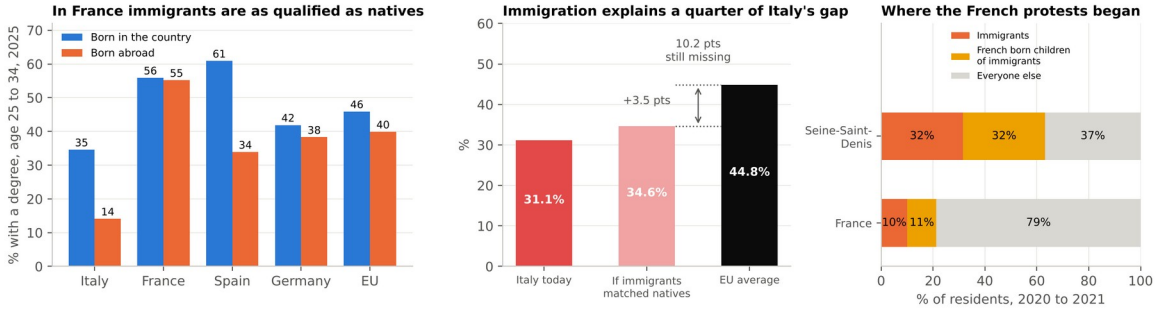
Chapter 3 Who is on the street, and why

Is it the immigrants?

Short answer, no, and the long answer is more interesting. The question came from the photos, so it is worth being clear about what photos can and cannot show. A camera in one suburb shows that suburb. It tells you nothing about who is marching in Lyon, Turin or Novi Sad, and nothing about how many

people with each background are protesting. For that you need data, and Figure 6 uses three pieces of it (Model 06).

Figure 6: Immigration is part of Italy's story and almost none of France's



Source: author's model 06; Eurostat edat_lfs_9912 (2025); INSEE (localisation des immigrés et descendants, 2020 to 2021 averages).

Start with Serbia, which has had the biggest student movement of the three. It is a country people emigrate from, not to, and its protesters are Serbian students marching about corruption at home. Immigration plays no part in that story.

In France the movement began in the working class suburbs north and east of Paris, in Seine-Saint-Denis and Val-de-Marne [WIKI1, AJ2]. INSEE, the French statistics office, counts 31.6% of the residents of Seine-Saint-Denis as immigrants and another 31.6% as French born children of immigrants, compared with 10% and 11% for France as a whole [INSEE1]. So yes, if the pictures you saw came from those schools, many of the faces will belong to families who came from somewhere else. But the pupils are mostly the second group. They were born in France, are French citizens and go to French state schools, and the protests started there over missing teachers and run down buildings [AJ2]. They are arguing for education because they are the ones not getting enough of it. Donald Trump called the unrest "out of control mass migration" and said it was about Islam, but the students' demands mention neither religion nor migration [SIA1]. They ask for replacement teachers, better buildings and a shorter school day [SIA1]. The national data backs this up. Among French 25 to 34 year olds, 55.9% of those born in France have a degree and 55.2% of those born abroad do, almost exactly the same [DATA1]. Immigration does not explain anything about France's education average.

Italy is where immigration does matter, and it would be dishonest to pretend otherwise. Only 14.1% of Italy's young adults born abroad have a degree, against 34.6% of those born in Italy, and a quarter of foreign born 18 to 24 year olds leave school early, against 6.7% of natives [DATA1]. From the published rates I estimate that about 17% of Italian 25 to 34 year olds were born abroad. If they had the same degree rate as natives, Italy's figure would rise from 31.1% to 34.6%. That closes 3.5 of the 13.7 point gap to the EU, about a quarter. The other three quarters is Italians born in Italy, whose rate of 34.6% is still eleven points below native born Europeans as a whole. My reading is that Italy has mostly attracted immigrants for low wage work rather than for study, so this gap says more about who comes than about Italian classrooms.

And in Italy the students are protesting against an immigration measure, not for one. One of their complaints on 16 October was a decree that caps at 30% the share of foreign born pupils without enough years of Italian schooling in first year classes [IP1, IP2]. About 911,000 of Italy's 7.7 million pupils, 11.8%, lack Italian citizenship, and researchers at the Politecnico di Milano estimate the decree's rules touch only 155 classes and about 290 pupils at risk of being moved [IP2]. So the people marching are mostly Italian teenagers objecting to a policy aimed at foreign children, plus the cost of school, the state of buildings and a new four year technical track they see as too tied to employers [IP1].

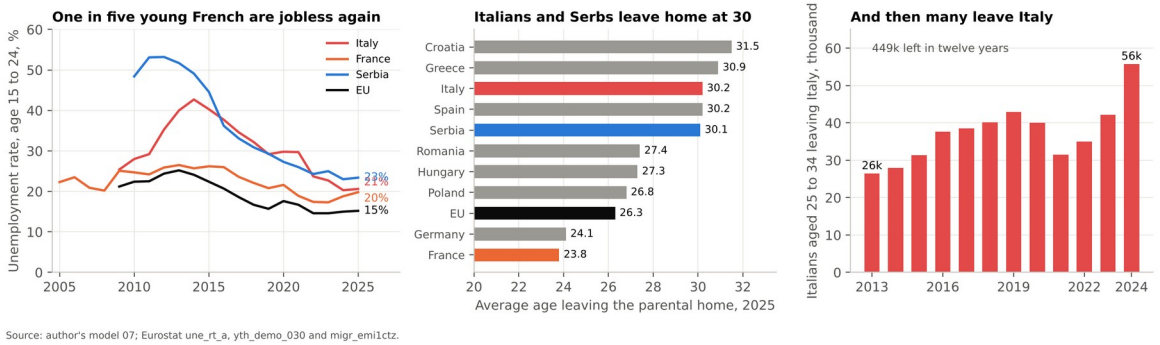
Question **Then why did the protests in France turn so violent?**

Answer Several things at once. Some of the violence was arson, looting and attacks on police, and French intelligence reportedly described the movement as organised by La France Insoumise and its allies, which the party denies and calls spontaneous [WIKI1]. The police response was also heavy, with more than 6,800 people taken into custody, most of them minors, a 15 year old losing a hand to a stun grenade and Amnesty International calling the force disproportionate [WIKI1, AJ2]. Both can be true. Violence by a minority does not tell you who the majority were or what they wanted, and the demands of the lycée unions were about teachers and buildings from the first day [WIKI1].

What is really driving it

If it is not immigration, what is it? Figure 7 is my best answer (Model 07). In France one in five young people in the labour force is out of work, 19.8%, up from 17.3% three years ago [DATA1]. In Italy it is 20.6%, much better than the 42.7% of 2014 but still well above the EU's 15.2%. The average young Italian leaves the parental home at 30.2, the same as in Serbia, against 23.8 in France and 26.3 in the EU [DATA1].

Figure 7: A generation that cannot start its life at home



Source: author's model 07; Eurostat une_rt_a, yth_demo_030 and migr_emi1ctz.

The third panel is the one that worries me most. In 2013 about 26,000 Italian citizens aged 25 to 34 left Italy. In 2024 it was almost 56,000, and over the twelve years nearly 450,000 left [DATA1]. These figures cover all levels of education and include people who became Italian by naturalisation, so they are not purely a brain drain. But a country that produces too few graduates and then loses a growing number of its young adults abroad is running to stand still. The same logic drove the Serbian students. They saw the exit as the only option and decided to try to change things at home instead.

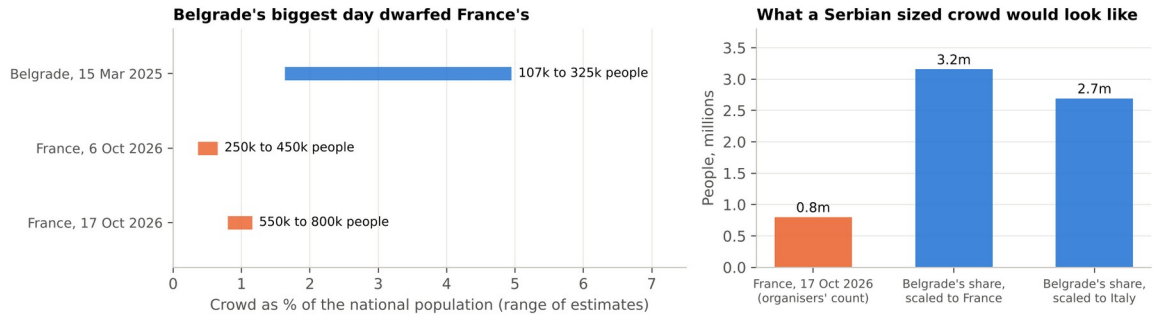
Underneath all three movements is the same feeling, which a political scientist quoted in La Estrella de Panamá described as young people believing that the future and progress promised by Europe's welfare states have become less real than they were told [LE1]. Education is where that promise is most visible. It is supposed to be the deal. Study hard and you get a job, a home and a life. When the school has no maths teacher, the degree does not lead to a job, or the job is in another country, the deal looks broken.

How big were the crowds?

Crowd counts are always political, so Figure 8 shows each protest as a range from the lowest to the highest published estimate and divides it by the country's population (Model 08). France's largest day, 17 October, brought out 0.8% to 1.2% of the population. Belgrade on 15 March 2025 brought out between 1.6% and 4.9% of Serbia's, and about 4.6% on the independent count [BETA1, AJ2, WIKI1]. To

match that share of the population France would need about 3.2 million people in the streets on one day and Italy about 2.7 million. That is why Serbia's movement became a political force that could win an election while the French and Italian ones are, for now, pressure on budgets.

Figure 8: Relative to its size, Serbia mobilised several times more people



Source: author's model 08; Beta (Archive of Public Gatherings and police, 2025); Al Jazeera and Wikipedia (French counts, Oct 2026); Eurostat demo_gind.

Chapter 4 What I take from all this

The answers

Who is arguing for education? In all three countries it is mostly young people born there, and in France many of them are the children of immigrants in the poorest suburbs, who are French and are asking for the teachers their schools do not have. They argue for education for the same reason anyone protests, because they are the ones paying for its failures.

Why is the average low? In France it is not. France has one of the highest shares of young graduates in Europe and its problem is falling school standards and youth unemployment. In Italy the average really is low, and the reasons are structural. Italy spends less on education than almost any of the EU countries I looked at, has almost no two year degrees, and loses tens of thousands of young adults abroad every year. Immigration explains about a quarter of the gap, and the other three quarters is made in Italy.

And Serbia? Serbia is the proof that students can do more than march. Starting from a canopy collapse, they built a movement that, relative to the size of the country, mobilised several times more people than France has, and turned it into a majority of about 141 seats on the highest turnout in decades. The hard part starts now. A shrinking population, income at half the Italian level and twenty years of catching up with Croatia are not things an election fixes.

What I am watching

In Serbia I am watching three things. The first is the final RIK count and whether the minority lists change the seat split, the second is who the students put forward as prime minister, and the third is whether there is real progress on the Novi Sad investigation. In France I am watching whether the government changes the 2027 budget for schools before the presidential election in April 2027, and whether the protests come back after the school holidays [AJ2, WIKI1]. In Italy I am watching how many classes the foreign pupil cap actually touches when it is applied, and the 2025 emigration figures when Eurostat publishes them.

None of the three governments can say it was not warned. The data has been pointing the same way for a decade.

Data and method

All numbers come from public sources. Education, labour market, population and migration data come from the Eurostat dissemination API, downloaded on 26 October 2026, and income per head comes from the IMF World Economic Outlook of October 2026 through the OpenBB platform [DATA1, DATA2]. Serbian results come from the Republic Electoral Commission count at 96.9% of polling stations as reported on the morning of 26 October, and will change slightly in the final count [SD1]. Figures quoted from articles are listed in 03 Data/hand_collected_sources.csv with their source and link. The seat projection in Model 01 uses only the minority lists whose shares were published. Model 04's thought experiment is an upper bound and assumes students on two year degrees graduate at the same rate as everyone else. Model 06 backs the foreign born share out of three rounded published rates, so it carries some rounding error. Crowd counts in Model 08 are ranges because there is no neutral count. I am not affiliated with any party, school or campaign in the three countries.

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